

off. I placed and timed the ball well, but my speed and spin need work," he admitted.

A former World No.1 in Under-21 (2020), Thakkar struggled for consistency at the senior level. Training under Pfeiffer at Sharath's academy in Chennai and competing in the French league with Top 10 stars Felix and Alexis Lebrun, he has become more proactive. "Earlier, he played safe. Now, he attacks more," Pfeiffer noted.

His Chennai success propelled him to a career-high World No. 47. Still chasing his first National Championship, his breakthrough at home signals a turning point. The next big test? Breaking into Grand Smashes and WTT Champions.

Meanwhile, another Indian, wildcard Snehit Suravajjula, made waves in Chennai. He stunned Japan's World No. 29 Yukiya Uda 3-2 after saving three match points. Then, in a mentor-vs-protégé clash, he defeated Sharath 3-0, denying the veteran a fairytale ending. Snehit lost 1-3 to Poret in the quarterfinals but achieved a career-best World No. 89 ranking. Other Indian contenders had mixed results. Reigning national champion Manush Shah (World No. 73) and Paris Olympian Harmeet (World No. 68) exited in the round of 32. Sathian (World No. 105) fell in the first round.

There were 28 Indians in the men's singles qualifying draw. Out of them, Divyansh Srivastava, Payas Jain and Anirban Ghosh managed to clinch three of the eight spots available in the main draw.

"With Sathian and Harmeet as seniors, and young talents like Manav, Manush, Snehit, Payas, and Ankur (Bhattacharjee) coming up, I'm



Going down fighting: Manav Thakkar's impressive run at the WTT Star Contender in Chennai ended in a 3-1 semifinal loss to World No. 54 Thibault Poret. M. VEDHAN

confident Indian table tennis is in safe hands," said Sharath after his final match.

In 2026, India will have two big team competitions at the ITTF World Team Table Tennis Championships Finals and the Asian Games. A lot will depend on the consistency of the doubles pair of Manav and Manush, the only Indian duo in the Top 10, as well as the development of the current batch of singles to do well at these events.

A podium finish (India won a historic first-ever bronze in 2018 but lost in the quarterfinals in 2023), in the absence of someone as experienced as Sharath, will take something extraordinary.

The upcoming World Cup (From April 14-20 in Macao, China) and World Championships (From May 17-25 in Doha) will provide a clearer picture of Indian table tennis in the post-Sharath era.



Meet the champions

Men's Singles

Oh Jun-sung (South Korea)

Women's Singles

Miwa Harimoto (Japan)

Men's Doubles

Lim Jong-hoon and An Jae-hyun (South Korea)

Women's Doubles

Miwa Harimoto and Miyuu Kihara (Japan)

Mixed Doubles

Lim Jong-Hoon and Shin Yu-Bin (South Korea)